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September 26, 1994

TO:

FROM: INR/GGI - Bill Wood
INR/GGI - Don Krumm

SUBJECT: Proposal for a Crisis Information Sharing Network:
RELIEFNET

The following is a draft plan for RELIEFNET, a proposed information sharing network for relief agencies, including those in the UN, the USG, and the NGO communities. We would very much appreciate your thoughts and suggestions on the feasibility of this plan and on who might wish to become part of the network. We hope to discuss this plan with UN officers as well as interested State and AID colleagues on October 3, 2:30-4:30, in room 5533 (EB Conference room). Our phone numbers are 7-2021 or 7-1935.

Statement of Purpose

To plan more effectively for humanitarian relief efforts in crisis-prone countries, potential relief providers--including NGOs, governments, UN agencies--must improve data collection and the way they share information on early warning indicators. An information sharing network (with linked electronic databases and bulletin boards) must be an integral part of more efficient, comprehensive efforts to improve multilateral coordination in anticipation of and in response to humanitarian crises.

-- The basic principle of RELIEFNET is that participating agencies will benefit by having real time access to all aspects of a crisis while voluntarily contributing a small subset of data (usually data that are already being collected). Moreover, it provides an open forum for "early warning awareness"--ideally directly from the field missions--to all interested parties.

-- Crises that require a multilateral response are often complex and fast-breaking. No intervening agency can afford to duplicate all the data collection and analysis efforts of others through the crisis continuum--from "early warning" to "post crisis transition". RELIEFNET can be used to track indicators in crisis-prone countries.

-- All relief-related agencies need knowledgeable, timely information about changing crisis conditions and likely problems so that their own decision makers can obtain resources and plan appropriate strategies. RELIEFNET allows users to query ongoing files as often as needed, as well as debate issues with other crisis experts via a "bulletin board" on a particular sub-field;

NGO participation?

thus a relief worker in one remote site can immediately provide updated information to all other interested agencies.

-- Most agencies have some operational specialty which gives them a comparative advantage in data collection and analysis over some aspect of a crisis. RELIEFNET is simply a means for them to voluntarily make available relevant information without compromising their own data collection and decision-making processes.

-- As an Internet-based network, RELIEFNET will allow users to access updated data from others via a "home page" that directs them to the Internet address that has the information they want. RELIEFNET will function so that contributing agencies only copy to the network what they want to share; their own original databases cannot be altered by other users.

-- Several agencies have already started their own networked databases, some of which include crisis-relevant information; these will be the building blocks for expanding RELIEFNET. The UN/DHA, in particular, has a need to facilitate information sharing with UN and even NGO relief agencies.

Types of Linked Crisis Databases and Bulletin Boards

The Database would be based on a Menu-driven system, initially beginning with a list of crisis-prone countries (perhaps 25) and a Functional File on data or reports that might apply to all countries (e.g., global food availability, or new medicines, or relief equipment). Each selected country would have a menu of files, such as the following (including possible contributing agencies):

- 1) MAPS AND GENERAL BACKGROUND
(possibly basic GIS-type datasets)
 - a) base features and information (roads, ports, topography, general miscellaneous information about high risk places and areas)
 - DeLorme Mapping; DMA, State, DHA
 - b) thematic maps (refugee flows, lines of conflict, political jurisdictions, ethnic homelands)
 - State, DHA
 - c) imagery - EOSAT, SPOT
 - d) field mapping (such as refugee camp sites or current road conditions for relief convoys)
- 2) GROUPS AT RISK (DPs and refugees)
 - NGOs (US Committee for Refugees, Refugees International), UNHCR, DHA, UNDP, PRM, INR, OFDA, Refugee Policy Group
- 3) PUBLIC HEALTH (conditions in camps or in a country)

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- WHO, CDC, MSF

- 4) FOOD/WATER (production/distribution; droughts; hunger)
 - USAID (FEWS), DOA, FAO, WFP, UNICEF
- 5) DISASTERS (natural disaster/environmental hazards and degradation)
 - OFDA (DART), FEMA, UNEP, DHA
- 6) POLITICS/CIVIL UNREST (Elections, political factions, ethno-political instability and human rights abuses)
 - Human Rights NGOs, INR, Embassies (via unclassified, specially tagged reporting cables) HR
- 7) ECONOMY (macro-economic development trends, exchange rates, as well as relevant reporting on crime, black market trade, smuggling)
 - World Bank, IMF, UNDP, USAID, EC
- 8) LOGISTICS (troubleshooting problems in providing relief)
 - NGOs, OFDA (DART), DOD
- 9) DISPUTES (key disputes--land, water, borders, language, ethnicity--and efforts at conflict mediation)
 - Conflict mediators
- 10) EXPERTS AND KEY RELIEF AGENCIES (Contact list of relief and country experts; key agencies and their relevant missions and programs)
- 11) BULLETIN BOARD (immediate information sharing on: food needs, shelter, emergency assistance, medical needs, infrastructure repair); linkages with other bulletin boards (such as AIDNET, IRIS) ERRIS?
- 12) HELP (system related advice)

Plan of Action

1) Meeting with State, USAID, UN, and several key NGOs to discuss whole concept, key players, institutional/technical concerns, and development of a single country prototype -- tentative date is Oct. 3 with other State and USAID bureaus, UN/DHA, PKO and other key NGOs (Interaction)

a) Build prototype "open source" data base for one crisis-vulnerable country organized along above criteria); b) Establish and learn Internet type connections and the mechanics of setting up RELIEFNET

2) Host a workshop of representatives of key agencies and possible contributors to a RELIEFNET system to outline what are

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critical factors, what is expected, limitations, data contributions and sharing rules, institutional commitments, timeframe, etc... Demonstration of on-line capabilities and country prototype

Possible participants would include:

State - INR, PRM, G, DHL, IO, USUN
UN - DHA, PKO, UNDP, UNHCR, WFP, FAO
USAID - A, BHR, OFDA, ENI, G
DOD - Office of Refugees and Humanitarian Affairs
Relief NGOs - Interaction (plus NGOs interested in contributing)
Think Tanks - USIP, CSIS
Congressional Hunger Committee
Center for International Development and Conflict Management, University of Maryland
DeLorme Mapping - David DeLorme
Victim Advocates - Amnesty, USCR, RI, etc.

Ch...
Intelligence
Other Academic Projects

- 3) Take plan and prototype to senior policy makers in UN, USG, Congress, and NGOs as a concrete program for improving multilateral responses to crises - funding for terminals (e.g. laptop-satellite-internet links for use in crisis prone countries)
- 4) Build on-going databases, with perhaps a separate agency responsible for maintaining a particular category of information (e.g., WFP - food, UNHCR - refugees, ICRC - DPs, etc...)
- 5) Establish bulletin boards with on-going, real-time information exchanges on crises and countries
- 6) Outreach to field missions to establish field to HQ and field to field linkages - UN, State, USAID, NGOs